TEXORA · LECTURE SHEET

Fashion Terminology

The working vocabulary of fashion — style, fashion, trend, fad and classic; the couture-to-street levels of the trade; and the cycle every fashion travels — defined precisely, because in this industry these words carry commercial meaning.

AM-4203 · FASHION DESIGN AND PRODUCT ENGINEERING · TOPIC 1 · LEVEL 4 TERM 2

1. Why terminology is a technical subject

Fashion words are used loosely in everyday speech and precisely in the trade, and the difference costs money: a buyer who orders a "fad" item in classic quantities, or a designer who presents a "style" as a "trend", has made a commercial error with vocabulary. This sheet fixes the core terms in their trade senses; every later topic in this course uses them as defined here.

2. The five words that must not be confused

TERM	TRADE MEANING
Style	A particular look or form — a distinctive combination of silhouette, details and materials (for example, a safari jacket, a sari drape, a three-piece suit). Styles exist whether or not anyone is currently wearing them; a museum is full of styles and empty of fashion.
Fashion	A style that is *accepted and worn by a significant group at a given time*. Fashion is style plus acceptance plus a time limit: the same garment is fashion in one season, dated in the next, and possibly fashion again decades later.
Trend	The direction in which fashion acceptance is moving — rising, peaking or declining — read from sales, street adoption and media signals. A trend is a movement, not an object.
Fad	A fashion of very short life: rapid rise, brief peak, rapid disappearance, usually carried by novelty rather than usefulness. Fads are profitable only to those who exit on time.
Classic	A fashion that never fully leaves: acceptance continues season after season because the design satisfies a lasting need (the white shirt, the straight trouser, the navy blazer). Classics are the low-risk core of a range.

3. The fashion cycle

Every fashion moves through five stages, and the stage — not the garment — decides the correct production quantity and price strategy.

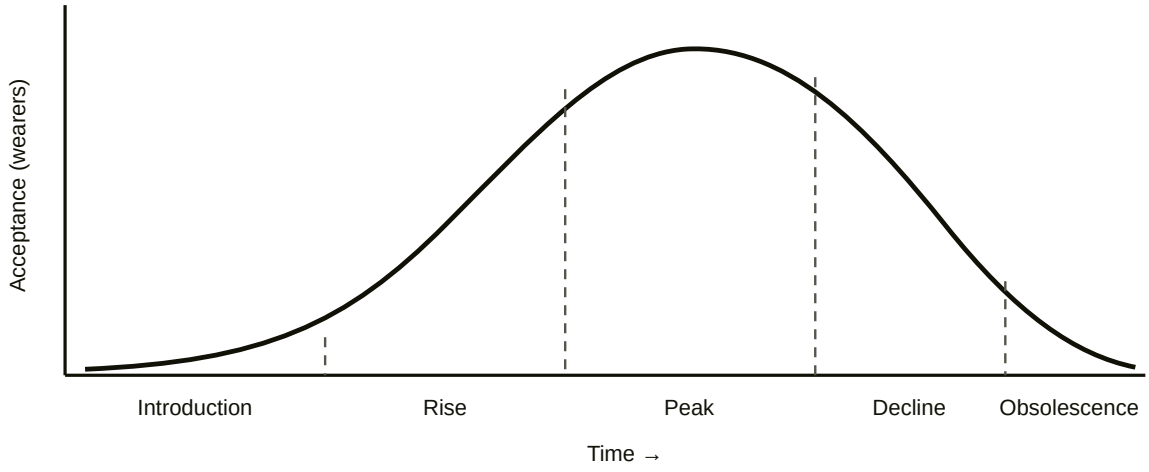


Figure 1 — The fashion cycle. A classic flattens the curve after the peak instead of falling to zero; a fad compresses the same five stages into a few weeks.

1. **Introduction.** A new style is offered, usually at high price and small quantity; only fashion leaders adopt it.
2. **Rise.** Acceptance spreads; imitations appear at lower prices; production quantities grow.
3. **Peak (culmination).** Maximum acceptance; the style is everywhere, in every price band — and saturation has begun.
4. **Decline.** Wearers tire of the style; markdowns start; production must already have been cut.
5. **Obsolescence.** The style is rejected as dated; remaining stock is cleared at any price. Some styles later return — a *revival* — but on a new cycle, not a continuation of the old one.

4. Levels and sectors of the trade

TERM	MEANING
Haute couture	The highest level: made-to-measure garments designed for an individual client, produced in a couture house's atelier with extensive hand work. A protected designation in France, governed by its official body; elsewhere used loosely for top-level custom work.
Prêt-à-porter / ready-to-wear	Designer-level fashion produced in standard sizes for retail sale — the level at which most designed fashion reaches the market.
Mass fashion / high street	Large-volume ready-to-wear at accessible prices, produced by the apparel industry of this degree's other courses.

Fast fashion	A supply model, not a price level: trend items moved from design to store in very short lead times and small, frequently renewed batches.
Slow fashion	The counter-position: durable design and construction, timeless styling, and longer garment life as the selling point.
Avant-garde	Design that runs deliberately ahead of acceptance — experimental forms shown to move the boundary of what will later be wearable.
Vintage / retro	*Vintage*: genuinely old garments of an earlier period, worn now. *Retro*: new garments designed in the manner of an earlier period. The words are not interchangeable in trade descriptions.
Capsule wardrobe	A small set of garments designed to combine freely with each other, covering the wearer's needs with few pieces.

5. Design-room and range vocabulary

Silhouette — the outer outline of the garment on the body; the fastest-changing and most defining element of a fashion (Topic 4). **Line** — both the direction of seams and visual paths within a design, and, in trade usage, a designer's collection for a season ("the autumn line"). **Collection / range** — the set of styles offered together for a season. **Theme / story** — the unifying idea (colour palette, fabrics, mood) that makes a collection read as one statement (Topic 6). **Sample** — the prototype garment; the *sealed sample* is the approved reference for production. **Size range** — the set of sizes offered; **size ratio** — the proportions in which they are produced. **Colourway** — one colour version of a style. **Coordinates** — separate garments designed to be worn together. **Bestseller / repeater** — a style that sells through and is re-ordered — the commercial opposite of the fad that was over-bought.

Glossary

TERM	MEANING
Acceptance	The adoption of a style by a significant number of wearers; the event that turns a style into a fashion.
Fashion leader	An early adopter whose visible use of a new style influences others at the introduction stage.
Markdown	A reduction from the original selling price, typically signalling the decline stage.
Revival	The return of an obsolete style as a new fashion, beginning a new cycle.

Sell-through	The share of stock sold at full price within the season; the retail measure that separates bestsellers from fads mis-bought.

Key points and summary

- Style is the form; fashion is style + acceptance + time; a trend is the direction of movement; fads are short fashions; classics are fashions that persist.
- The fashion cycle — introduction, rise, peak, decline, obsolescence — drives quantity and price decisions at every stage.
- Trade levels run from haute couture through ready-to-wear to mass fashion; fast and slow fashion are supply philosophies, not price levels.
- Precise words (vintage vs retro, line as direction vs collection, silhouette vs shape) are professional tools, not decoration.

Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. Classify each as fad, fashion, classic or style only, and justify in one line: (a) a novelty phone-case garment accessory that sells out in one month and disappears; (b) the men's white dress shirt; (c) a 1920s flapper dress in a museum; (d) a colour that has risen through two seasons of rising sales.
2. A buyer says of a garment at the peak stage: "It is selling everywhere, so double the order." Give the cycle-based objection.
3. Distinguish vintage from retro, and line in its two trade senses.
4. Why is "fast fashion" not a price level?

Answer key

1. (a) Fad — complete cycle compressed into weeks. (b) Classic — acceptance persists across seasons. (c) Style only — a form with no current acceptance, hence not a fashion now. (d) A trend — the item described is a movement (rising acceptance of a colour), not a garment.
2. Peak is the last stage before decline: saturation is already present, and a doubled order arrives as acceptance falls, converting directly into markdown stock. The correct action at peak is to harvest sales and cut forward commitments.
3. Vintage garments are genuinely from an earlier period; retro garments are new products designed after an earlier period. Line means (1) the visual direction within a design and (2) a designer's seasonal collection.

4. Because it describes how quickly and in what batch pattern product reaches the store — a supply model that can be operated at several price levels — not where the product sits in the couture-to-mass hierarchy.
